

Committee: United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC)

Topic: Evaluating the Role of Artificial Intelligence in Strategic Warfare and Its Impact on Civilian Casualties

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1. Introduction

The integration of Artificial Intelligence into military operations represents one of the most significant transformations in the history of armed conflict. From the battlefields of Gaza and Ukraine to the strategic calculations of major powers, AI systems are reshaping how wars are fought, how targets are selected, and how decisions about life and death are made. As BBC news reports, Ukraine has been using AI-enabled drones to strike Russian supply lines over 100 miles from the front, representing a significant shift in battlefield capabilities. While these technologies promise unprecedented efficiency and the potential for greater precision, their deployment has raised some urgent questions about the protection of civilians and the application of international law in warfare. According to Human Rights Watch, the Israeli military's use of digital tools in Gaza has raised profound concerns about civilian protection and compliance with international law.

For the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, this topic carries particular weight. UNODC's mandate: combating drugs, organized crime, corruption, and terrorism, increasingly intersects with the challenges posed by emerging technologies. AI systems developed for military purposes may be repurposed by non-state actors, including terrorist organizations, while the proliferation of AI-enabled surveillance and targeting technologies raises profound human rights concerns. The convergence of military AI with the threats UNODC is mandated to address demands a comprehensive, rights-based response.

This Chair Report is designed to provide delegates with the analytical foundation necessary for informed debate. It defines the essential terms, explores the historical and contemporary context of military AI, examines the perspectives of key stakeholders, and poses critical questions to guide the committee toward actionable recommendations. Whether you are approaching this topic for the first time or bringing prior expertise, this report aims to equip you with the knowledge and frameworks needed to contribute meaningfully to the discussion.

2. Definition of Essential Terms

a) Artificial Intelligence (AI) in Military Contexts: The application of machine learning, neural networks, and other computational techniques to enhance or automate military functions. This includes intelligence analysis, decision-support, targeting, and autonomous weapons operation. AI systems do not actually "think" like humans but rather identify patterns in vast datasets and generate recommendations or actions based on those patterns.

b) Algorithmic Targeting: The use of AI systems to identify, evaluate, and prioritize potential military targets. These systems analyze data from multiple sources like surveillance footage, communications intercepts, social media, and other intelligence to generate lists of individuals or objects deemed to pose a threat. Unlike traditional targeting, which relies heavily on human intelligence and judgment, algorithmic targeting operates at a scale and speed that human analysts cannot match.

c) Autonomous Weapons Systems (AWS): Weapons that, once activated, can select and engage targets without further human intervention. The international community remains divided on whether such systems can ever comply with international humanitarian law. The UN Secretary-General has called for a legally binding instrument to prohibit systems that function without meaningful human control.

d) Civilian Casualties: Non-combatants killed or injured as a result of military operations. The protection of civilians is a central concern of international humanitarian law and a key focus of this committee's deliberations. AI systems have the potential to reduce civilian casualties through improved targeting precision, but operational experience suggests they may also enable levels of destruction that undermine the protective purpose of international law.

e) Decision-Support Systems (DSS): AI systems that assist human commanders by generating recommendations, scoring individuals or objects based on predicted threat levels, or organizing battlefield data. These systems do not typically operate autonomously but significantly shape

human decision-making. The distinction between DSS and fully autonomous systems is crucial. Most AI currently used in warfare falls into this category, raising questions about the quality and meaningfulness of human oversight.

f) International Humanitarian Law (IHL): The body of law, also known as the laws of war or the Geneva Conventions, that regulates the conduct of armed conflict. Its core principles are:

- Distinction: Parties to conflict must distinguish between civilians and combatants, and between civilian objects and military objectives.
- Proportionality: Incidental civilian harm must not be excessive in relation to the anticipated military advantage.
- Precaution: All feasible measures must be taken to avoid civilian harm.

These principles are universally accepted but their application to AI-enabled warfare is complex and contested.

g) Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS): A subset of autonomous weapons designed specifically to kill or incapacitate. The governance of LAWS has been a central focus of international disarmament discussions, with states divided on whether to pursue a comprehensive ban or more limited regulation.

h) Meaningful Human Control: A governance concept requiring that human operators retain sufficient control over weapons systems to ensure compliance with international law. While there is broad agreement that total automation is unacceptable, there is considerable debate about what constitutes "meaningful" control in practice.

i) Proliferation: The spread of military AI technologies to state and non-state actors beyond their original developers. Proliferation risks include the acquisition of dangerous capabilities by terrorist organizations, the erosion of strategic stability, and the difficulty of verifying compliance with international norms.

j) Strategic Warfare: The use of military force to achieve political objectives at the highest level, including the targeting of an adversary's military, economic, and political infrastructure. AI is transforming strategic warfare by enabling rapid analysis of complex systems and precise strikes against critical nodes, but it also risks lowering the threshold for conflict and accelerating escalation.

3. General Context

Warfare has always been shaped by technology, and the current transformation driven by artificial intelligence is as significant as any that preceded it. The introduction of gunpowder, the rifle, the machine gun, the tank, the airplane, and the nuclear weapon each transformed how wars were fought and brought new horrors along with new legal frameworks designed to limit those horrors. Unlike previous technological shifts, however, AI does more than simply enhance existing capabilities. It fundamentally changes the nature of decision-making in war. When machines can process information and generate recommendations at speeds that exceed human cognition, the relationship between human judgment and military action is altered in ways we are only beginning to understand (Carnegie Endowment for International Peace).

In Gaza, Ukraine, and elsewhere, AI systems are actively generating targeting recommendations, estimating collateral damage, and informing strategic decisions. According to the Institute for AI Policy and Strategy, these systems are effectively producing manifold increases in daily targets. This dramatic expansion of capacity forces us to confront difficult questions about restraint, accountability, and the future of international law.

Proponents of military AI point to several genuine advantages. These systems can process vast quantities of data that would overwhelm human analysts, improving situational awareness and decision-making. They can identify patterns that humans might miss, potentially enhancing targeting precision and reducing civilian harm. They can operate at speeds that enable rapid response to emerging threats. They can also assume dangerous or monotonous tasks, reducing the exposure of military personnel to harm. For civilian protection, these are not trivial benefits. Improved surveillance and targeting could, in theory, result in fewer accidental strikes on

civilians. AI could enhance early warning systems, giving civilians more time to evacuate. AI could also support humanitarian assessments, enabling more effective delivery of aid to affected populations.

However, these promises must be weighed against significant risks. AI systems are not neutral tools. They reflect the biases and assumptions of their developers and the data on which they are trained. As Laura Bruun and Marta Bo argue in their research on bias in military AI, incomplete or biased training data can produce discriminatory outcomes. In warfare, this could mean systematically targeting certain populations or misidentifying civilian objects as military objectives. More fundamentally, AI systems cannot make the kind of contextual, qualitative judgments that international humanitarian law requires. Proportionality, for example, requires commanders to weigh expected civilian harm against anticipated military advantage. This is not a calculation that can be reduced to an algorithm. It requires human judgment about values, consequences, and the specific circumstances of each operation. As the International Committee of the Red Cross emphasizes in its position paper on autonomous weapon systems, it is not the weapon systems that must comply with IHL, but the humans using it. When commanders defer to algorithmic assessments without exercising their own independent judgment, they risk undermining the very protections that IHL is designed to provide. There is also the risk of escalation. If decisions are made at machine speed, the time for deliberation and de-escalation are often compressed. A strike that might have been reconsidered under traditional processes may proceed automatically when AI systems have already identified and prioritized the target.

International humanitarian law provides the framework for assessing the conduct of hostilities, and its principles apply fully to AI-enabled warfare. The challenge is not that IHL is inadequate but that AI systems may make compliance more difficult. The principle of distinction requires parties to distinguish between civilians and combatants. AI systems may enhance distinction through improved identification, but they may also generate false positives or fail to account for contextual factors essential to lawful targeting. An AI system that identifies a person as a combatant based on behavioral patterns may miss the fact that the person is actually a civilian who happens to behave in ways that resemble combatant activity. The principle of

proportionality is perhaps the most challenging. Proportionality requires a commander to determine whether incidental civilian harm is excessive in relation to the anticipated military advantage. This judgment requires understanding the military value of a target, the likely consequences of a strike, and the context in which the strike occurs. According to the ICRC, commanders are likely to defer to algorithmic assessments instead of exercising the independent judgment IHL requires when AI systems are the ones to generate the main recommendations. The principle of precaution requires parties to take all feasible measures to avoid civilian harm. As the ICRC has stated, AI systems may support these measures but they cannot substitute for human judgment about what is feasible in specific circumstances.

The relevance of this topic to the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime lies in the convergence of military AI with the threats UNODC is mandated to address. The proliferation of military AI technologies raises concerns that such capabilities could be acquired by non-state actors, including terrorist organizations. The United Nations Special Rapporteur on the promotion and protection of human rights while countering terrorism has highlighted the need to protect human rights while using AI to counter-terrorism. UNODC's counter-terrorism programs increasingly address the use of new technologies by terrorist groups, and the agency has expertise in assisting states to develop legal and technical capacities to counter these threats. UNODC's work on criminal justice and rule of law has direct relevance to AI accountability. The development of legal frameworks for AI responsibility requires expertise in international criminal law, evidence, and procedure, areas where UNODC has deep expertise. UNODC's mandate to assist states in protecting human rights and upholding the rule of law positions it to address the broader human rights implications of military AI. ICRC President Mirijana Spolijaric has emphasized that regulation of autonomous weapon systems is a matter of “humanity at a crossroads.” UNODC’s experience with transnational threats can also inform international responses to the proliferation of military AI. Drug trafficking, organized crime, and corruption all require international cooperation and capacity building, and the same is true for the regulation of dangerous technologies.

4. Key Parties Involved and their Perspectives

a) International Organizations

i) United Nations Security Council: The Security Council bears primary responsibility for maintaining international peace and security. While it has addressed AI in the context of specific conflicts, it has not yet adopted a comprehensive framework for military AI governance. The Council's responses to violations of international law in Gaza and Ukraine provide precedents for addressing AI-augmented warfare. The Council could play a crucial role in establishing norms, demanding accountability, and coordinating international action.

ii) United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC): UNODC's relevance to this topic lies in its mandate to combat terrorism, organized crime, and corruption. The agency also has expertise in criminal justice and human rights. UNODC can assist states in developing legal frameworks for AI accountability. It can help counter the proliferation of AI technologies to non-state actors. It can also support efforts to protect human rights in the context of AI-enabled surveillance and targeting.

iii) International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC): The ICRC is the guardian of international humanitarian law. It has consistently emphasized that IHL applies fully to autonomous weapons. The ICRC has also stated that states must regulate AI systems to ensure compliance with legal obligations. The organization has called for a legally binding instrument on LAWS. It has provided guidance on responsible AI in military contexts.

iv) UN Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA): UNODA leads UN efforts on conventional arms. This includes discussions on LAWS through the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW). UNODA also convenes the MAPS Dialogues, which foster inclusive multilateral dialogue on military AI. The office's work provides a foundation for broader UN action.

b) Major States

i) United States of America: The United States is a leading developer and user of military AI. Its Department of Defense has integrated AI systems into operations and, as the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace reports, the U.S. military's use of Palantir's Maven Smart Systems during the 2026 Iran War saw the Pentagon strike more than 13,000 targets over 38 days, with model token usage surging by 4,425 percent. The U.S. generally supports a governance approach that emphasizes responsible innovation, human control, and compliance with IHL. It has resisted a comprehensive treaty banning LAWS. Instead, it favors flexible, non-binding standards, as reflected in its position at the CCW Group of Governmental Experts.

ii) People's Republic of China: China has invested heavily in military AI. It has advanced a concept of "sovereign AI" that emphasizes technological self-reliance. China's position on LAWS has evolved toward support for regulation that ensures meaningful human control. However, it opposes restrictions that would limit its ability to develop AI capabilities. China emphasizes the importance of national sovereignty in governance frameworks. It has called for broader participation in AI governance discussions.

iii) Russian Federation: Russia has prioritized military AI as essential to maintaining strategic parity with the United States and China. It has opposed a comprehensive treaty banning LAWS. Russia has advocated for a more permissive approach that allows for innovation. The country's use of AI in Ukraine has been documented. This has raised concerns about compliance with IHL.

iv) United Kingdom: The UK has been a leading voice on AI governance. It emphasizes the importance of human control and accountability. The UK's Defence Artificial Intelligence Strategy articulates a commitment to responsible AI development and use. This commitment is informed by UK values and obligations under international law.

v) France: France has advanced a vision of "human-centered" AI governance. This vision emphasizes the need to preserve human agency and accountability. France also recognizes the

potential of AI for enhancing military effectiveness. The country has been active in multilateral discussions on LAWS.

vi) Israel: Israel has extensive experience with AI-enabled warfare. It has been a testing ground for military AI technologies. Israel's perspective is shaped by its security challenges and its leadership in AI innovation. The use of AI in Gaza has generated international scrutiny and debate. Israel argues that these technologies enhance precision and reduce civilian harm. Critics raise concerns about accountability and the erosion of legal protections.

5. Questions to Consider

1. How can the international community ensure that AI-enabled systems comply with international humanitarian law? Should new legally binding instruments be developed specifically for military AI?
2. What constitutes "meaningful human control" over AI-enabled military systems? How can we ensure human judgment and accountability are preserved?
3. How can UNODC and Member States balance emerging technology governance with civilian protection and accountability? What measures can protect civilians from the harmful effects of military AI?
4. How can accountability be ensured when AI systems contribute to IHL violations? What mechanisms should be established for investigating and remedying harm?
5. What measures can prevent the proliferation of military AI technologies to non-state actors, including terrorist organizations?
6. What role can UNODC play in assisting states to develop legal and technical capacities to counter the misuse of AI technologies by terrorist groups?
7. How can multilateral cooperation on military AI governance be strengthened? What would effective international cooperation look like?
8. How can the development and use of military AI be reconciled with international human rights law, including the rights to life, privacy, and non-discrimination?

6. Suggested Research Resources

- A. United Nations Institute for Disarmament Research (UNIDIR) - Artificial Intelligence in the Military Domain and Its Implications for International Peace and Security: An Evidence-Based Road Map for Future Policy Action

[https://docs-library.unoda.org/General_Assembly_First_Committee_-Eightieth_session_\(2025\)/79-239-UNIDIR-EN.pdf](https://docs-library.unoda.org/General_Assembly_First_Committee_-Eightieth_session_(2025)/79-239-UNIDIR-EN.pdf)

This report provides a comprehensive evidence-based roadmap for policy action on military AI, examining opportunities, challenges, and recommendations at the multilateral, regional, and national levels. It offers detailed analysis of command and control, intelligence, autonomy, and legal compliance issues, making it essential reading for delegates seeking to understand the full scope of AI's military applications.

- B. Africa Center for Strategic Studies - Artificial Intelligence for Africa's Defense Forces: A Toolkit for Defense Sector AI Strategy and Adoption

<https://africacenter.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/02/AI-for-Africas-Defense-Forces-Africa-Center-Toolkit.pdf>

This toolkit provides practical guidance for African policymakers and defense practitioners on AI adoption, including rationales, application areas, risk management frameworks, and strategy development. It includes case studies from across the continent and offers insights into adapting AI to Africa's unique security landscape, making it valuable for understanding regional perspectives and capacity-building needs.

- C. United Nations Regional Information Centre (UNRIC) - AI in Conflict: Keeping Humanity in Control

<https://unric.org/en/ai-in-conflict-keeping-humanity-in-control/>

This resource summarizes key debates from the 80th United Nations General Assembly on AI and international peace and security, including Secretary-General António Guterres' call for a ban on lethal autonomous weapons without human control. It outlines AI's

current military applications, associated risks, and existing UN system initiatives, providing an accessible overview of the international governance landscape.

D. United Nations Security Council Reports and Resolutions

<https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/content/reports>

This source includes official reports and resolutions established and published by the UNSC on matters of international peace and security. Documents are continuously published starting from the year 1946.

E. UN Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA) MAPS Dialogues

<https://disarmament.unoda.org/updates/>

This resource provides summaries of the Military AI, Peace & Security Dialogues, offering insights from multilateral discussions on military AI opportunities and risks, including state positions and emerging areas of consensus .

F. UN Institute for Disarmament Research (UNIDIR) Publications

<https://unidir.org/publication/>

This resource provides research on the interpretation and application of international humanitarian law to lethal autonomous weapons systems, offering detailed analysis of legal questions and state views .

G. International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) Position on Autonomous Weapons

<https://www.icrc.org/en/article/autonomous-weapon-systems-and-international-humanitarian-law-selected-issues>

This document outlines the ICRC's position on autonomous weapons and international humanitarian law, providing the perspective of the guardian of IHL on responsible AI in military contexts .

H. International Crisis Group

<https://www.crisisgroup.org/>

This resource provides independent analysis and concrete policy recommendations on conflict and technology, offering actionable recommendations for policymakers .

I. UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) - occupied Palestinian Territory

<https://www.ochaopt.org/>

This resource provides up-to-date humanitarian data on casualties, displacement, and access restrictions in the occupied Palestinian territory, offering essential context for understanding the humanitarian impact of AI-enabled conflict

7. Conclusion

The integration of artificial intelligence into strategic warfare represents one of the most significant challenges to international peace and security in the twenty-first century. While AI technologies offer potential benefits including enhanced precision, improved situational awareness, and the protection of military personnel, their deployment in contemporary conflicts has raised urgent questions about the protection of civilians, the application of international humanitarian law, and the future of human judgment in warfare.

For the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, the proliferation of military AI raises some serious concerns that such capabilities could be acquired by non-state actors, including terrorist organizations. The UNODC's counter-terrorism programs must adapt to address the misuse of AI by terrorist groups, assisting states in developing legal and technical capacities to counter these emerging threats. The agency's expertise in criminal justice and rule of law is also directly relevant to AI accountability, as the development of legal frameworks for AI responsibility requires deep knowledge of international criminal law, evidence and procedure. Furthermore, UNODC's mandate connects to the human rights implications of AI, including the rights to life, privacy, and non-discrimination. Finally, the agency's experience with transnational threats such as drug trafficking and organized crime provides a valuable model for addressing the transnational dimensions of military AI proliferation, which requires international cooperation and capacity building.

UNODC's contribution is essential in ensuring that responses to these challenges are grounded in human rights and effective criminal justice mechanisms. Delegates are encouraged to consider the full range of issues raised by military AI, including the legal and ethical frameworks that should govern its development and use, the practical measures needed to protect civilians, the mechanisms required for accountability, the strategies for preventing proliferation, and the role of international cooperation in addressing these challenges.

Through constructive debate and multilateral cooperation, the committee can contribute to developing the governance frameworks needed to address one of the most consequential challenges of our time. The decisions made in this committee and in the broader international community will shape the future of warfare and the protection of civilians for generations to come.

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